conservative daily *Slovenec* wrote about ‘big collectivist movements’: ‘Where are all these breeding grounds of revolutionary instincts and appetites supposed to end up, that Bolshevism, Fascism and Hitlerism, all children of the same mother, instil with such determination into the young generation? Where will materialise these new concepts about an absolute state, which on its own will, without regard for God’s or natural law, forms its own legal norms?’[48] So awareness of both dangers seemed to be present in Central Europe. Given the fears of Slavic nations that stood in the way of the Nazi ideology this was understandable.

After the Leninist revolution, the Soviet Union itself was not ready for the war and was desperate to do whatever was needed to appease Hitler. ‘Stalin realised that the working class of Europe were far too attached to bourgeois democracy to accept communism through violence’,[49] and through Comintern, demanded that Communist parties abroad should not attack Fascism and Nazism, not even in Italy and Germany.

The West too, as explained above, adopted a policy of appeasement towards Hitler and, in the Munich accord of 1938, sacrificed Czechoslovakia, the richest and most developed democracy of what was then Eastern Europe. ‘A quarrel in a far-away country between people of whom we know nothing’, are supposedly the words used by the British Prime Minister Chamberlain to dismiss the problems in Czechoslovakia and to justify his deal with Hitler.[50] Haslam points out that this was not only about buying time, but also about Chamberlain’s long-held view that too much money was spent on defence in the UK.[51] It would be up to Churchill to change that.

Among the countries desperate to avoid war was Czechoslovakia, which was, in many ways, a model country. It had a functioning democracy, a good economic base and an educated population, although the Czechs tended to look down on the much more rural Slovaks. It had a pro-Western foreign policy but its leaders, Masaryk and Beneš, were also not hostile at all towards the Soviet Union.

Poland was less a model democracy. Although there was a parliament and there were political parties, the country was effectively run as an authoritarian state under the leadership of Marshal Piłsudski. The country was predominantly rural, with a weak middle-class, and it had many more economic problems than Czechoslovakia, not least because it had